

Figure 2: Version 5.3 sports a revamped wallpaper

Note: Any CentOS user should have at least the RPMFusion, RPMForge and EPEL repos added. Lots of software is available in these repos that not only make our lives easier, but are also necessary for some tasks.

As for a LDAP server, CentOS includes CentOS Directory Server version 8.1.0. CentOS-DS is just a rebranded copy of Fedora Directory Server, so anyone with experience in FDS or Red Hat DS would have absolutely no trouble using CentOS-DS.

Now, let's come to virtualisation. CentOS includes Xen and QEMU. I was surprised to see something like KVM absent. Looks like KVM is in the *Extras* repository. I didn't install it, because my CPU doesn't support VT.

Virtualisation is provided by QEMU and Xen. Though management is a completely different matter. It is provided by some tool called Virt-Manager. Accessible from *Applications -> System Tools -> Virtual Machine Manager*, this tool has somewhat revolutionised virtualisation on Linux. It first made its mainstream appearance in Fedora 10. This tool follows a connection-based architecture. You open up this tool and connect to one or several machines and choose your Hypervisor of choice. It currently supports Xen, KVM and QEMU, so you're covered unless you are a VirtualBox fanatic like me.

Once you are connected to a machine, you create a new VM on it, using a wizard. Because it can use QEMU as a backend, in fully-virtualised mode, you can have i686, x86_64, ppc, sparc, mips and mipsel as architectures. Of course, in para-virtualised mode, you can only use your host arch. All other options are standard to what you would expect from VirtualBox. It's a very powerful tool. I say stick with it.

The other software are pretty typical. For DNS, a CHROOTED BIND 9.3.4 is installed. A 'Legacy Servers' group includes servers for Telnet, BootParamD, XinetD, RARPD, RSH, RUsers, RWWho, Talk and TFTP. The Network Servers group includes, amongst other things,

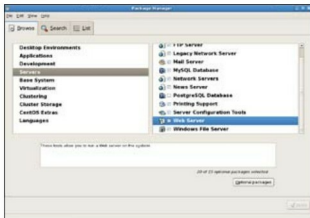


Figure 3: Numerous server software that are available

OpenLDAP, Amanda-server, DHCP, DHCPv6, Quagga, Privoxy, etc. There are GUI tools to manage servers, available from *System -> Administration -> Server Settings*. These GUI tools make life for sysadmins a lot easier. However, they do cut out some functionality, leaving no option but to manually edit files to change advanced settings.

Last but not the least, at the e-mail section, Dovecot is used as the default IMAP and POP3 daemon, but even though Postfix is included, Sendmail is still used as the default MTA. It's just a matter of removing Sendmail and installing Postfix, though.

Issues while running natively

My PC has an nVidia nForce Networking Controller. CentOS 5.3 refuses to work with it. To resolve this issue, manually download the latest `kmod-forcedeth` package from the updates repo and install it, then run `modprobe forcedeth`. Instant fix.

Another issue is that since NTFS is broken in the kernel, it is not provided and you have to install `ntfs-3g` from RPMForge. Even after installing it, drives are not recognised in the GNOME and KDE virtual filesystems and have to be mounted and browsed, manually.

We have better-looking and more expensive enterprise Linux options with more up-to-date software, but nothing beats CentOS. It's free, and it's so very modular that you can use it as your home OS with all multimedia codecs and 3D effects, and without any server software. It's so stable that only a power cut can bring it down. CentOS is just not something that can be laughed at. It might well be the world's best freebie out there. 

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The author is a 15-year-old student studying in Class 9. He is a logician (as opposed to a magician), a great supporter of Free Software and loves hacking Linux. Other than that, he is an experienced programmer in BASIC and can also program in C++, Python and Assembly (NASM Syntax).